A METHOD FOR CREATING VERIFIABLE PROOF OF POSSESSION OF NON-PUBLIC INFORMATION

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Title: A METHOD FOR CREATING VERIFIABLE PROOF OF POSSESSION OF NON-PUBLIC INFORMATION

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Abstract

A method for creating a verifiable, incontrovertible record that proves an individual was in possession of specific, non-public information at a point in time prior to that information's official public release. The method is designed to prove the existence of an information leak from a secure organization. It involves receiving a piece of secret information from a covert source, preparing a detailed written document that incorporates or acts upon said secret information, and submitting this document to a trusted, independent time-stamping authority before the information is made public. The discrepancy between the timestamp of the submitted document and the later timestamp of the official information release serves as verifiable proof of foreknowledge, thereby demonstrating the existence of the leak.

Background of the Invention

In the fields of counter-intelligence, corporate security, and investigative journalism, proving the existence of an information leak from a secure organization is exceptionally difficult. An individual may receive a tip from an anonymous source, but the information itself is often deniable. The source may be unwilling or unable to come forward. Without a verifiable chain of custody, the recipient of the leak is left with information that they cannot prove they had prior to its public disclosure, making it difficult to hold the leaking organization accountable.

For example, a whistleblower might inform a party that their legal filing will be rejected for a specific, non-obvious reason. If the party simply waits for the rejection, they have no proof of the leak. If they announce the leak beforehand, the organization can simply change its course of action to invalidate the claim. There is a need for a method that allows the recipient of a leak to create a permanent, time-stamped record of their foreknowledge without alerting the leaking organization.

Summary of the Invention

The present invention provides a systematic method for creating verifiable proof of possession of non-public information, referred to as the "Informant's Gambit." The method establishes a provable temporal paradox that demonstrates foreknowledge of a future event.

The method begins when an individual (the "Recipient") receives a piece of secret information from a covert source. This information pertains to a future action to be taken by a target organization. In a typical embodiment, the secret is the specific reason the organization will use to reject a document previously submitted by the Recipient.

Instead of waiting for the official action, the Recipient immediately prepares a detailed, formal written response. This response is specifically tailored to address the secret reason for rejection that was disclosed by the covert source. The response must be of sufficient complexity that it could not have been created extemporaneously.

The core of the method is the next step: the Recipient submits this formal response to a trusted, independent, and verifiable time-stamping authority. A preferred embodiment is a commercial courier service (e.g., FedEx), which creates a permanent, electronically-verifiable record of the exact date and time the document was tendered for delivery. This action is taken *before* the Recipient receives any official notification from the target organization.

Finally, the target organization takes its action, and the Recipient receives the official notification (e.g., the rejection letter). By comparing the courier's timestamp of the pre-

emptive response with the timestamp of the official notification, the Recipient can create an incontrovertible record proving they had precise knowledge of the organization's action and its justification hours or even days before it was officially communicated.

Brief Description of the Drawings

FIG. 1 is a timeline flowchart illustrating the sequence of events and the temporal paradox that creates the proof of a leak.

Detailed Description of the Invention

Referring to the timeline flowchart in **FIG. 1**, the method unfolds over a sequence of time-stamped events.

1. **T1: Covert Information Received (101):** The process begins when the Recipient receives a piece of non-public information from a covert source, such as an informant. The information details a specific future action to be taken by a target organization. For example, "Your application will be rejected because of reason X."

2. **T2: Preemptive Response Prepared (102):** The Recipient immediately prepares a detailed, formal document that specifically addresses or "fixes" the secret issue "X". This document is the "Preemptive Response."

3. **T3: Preemptive Response Submitted & Time-stamped (103):** This is the critical step. The Recipient tenders the Preemptive Response to a trusted, independent time-stamping authority, such as a commercial courier. The courier's system generates a verifiable, electronic timestamp (e.g., "Package tendered to FedEx at 9:14 AM"). This act is performed *before* any official communication is received from the target organization.

4. **T4: Official Notification Received (104):** At a later time, the Recipient receives the official notification from the target organization (e.g., a letter delivered by mail). The letter states that the application has been rejected for reason "X". This official notification has its own, later timestamp (e.g., "Letter delivered by USPS at 3:46 PM").

5. **Proof Established (105):** The proof of the information leak is established by the verifiable time gap between T3 and T4. The Recipient can present the courier's receipt

(proving the preemptive response was sent at 9:14 AM) alongside the official notification (proving the reason was not officially known until 3:46 PM). The fact that the preemptive response perfectly addresses the issue hours before it was officially known creates a temporal paradox that can only be explained by a leak of information from within the target organization.

Claims

What is claimed is:

1. A method for creating a verifiable record of possession of non-public information, comprising the steps of:

    - receiving a piece of non-public information concerning a future action to be taken by an organization;
    - preparing a written document that addresses or incorporates said non-public information;
    - submitting said written document to an independent, third-party time-stamping authority, thereby creating a first verifiable timestamp (T1); and
    - subsequently receiving an official communication from the organization which makes the non-public information public, said communication having a second verifiable timestamp (T2), wherein T2 is later than T1.

2. The method of claim 1, wherein the independent, third-party time-stamping authority is a commercial courier service.

3. The method of claim 1, wherein the non-public information is the specific reason for the future rejection of a previously submitted document.

4. The method of claim 3, wherein the prepared written document is an amended version of the previously submitted document which corrects the specific reason for rejection.

5. A method for demonstrating the existence of an information leak within an organization, comprising:

    - obtaining foreknowledge of a specific, detailed outcome of an internal process within the organization;
    - generating a tangible work product that demonstrates said foreknowledge;

- causing said tangible work product to be verifiably time-stamped by a trusted entity external to the organization; and
- preserving the record of said time-stamp for a future comparison against the time at which the organization publicly or officially discloses the outcome of its internal process.

6. The method of claim 5, wherein the tangible work product is a legal document and the trusted entity is a package delivery service.

Drawings

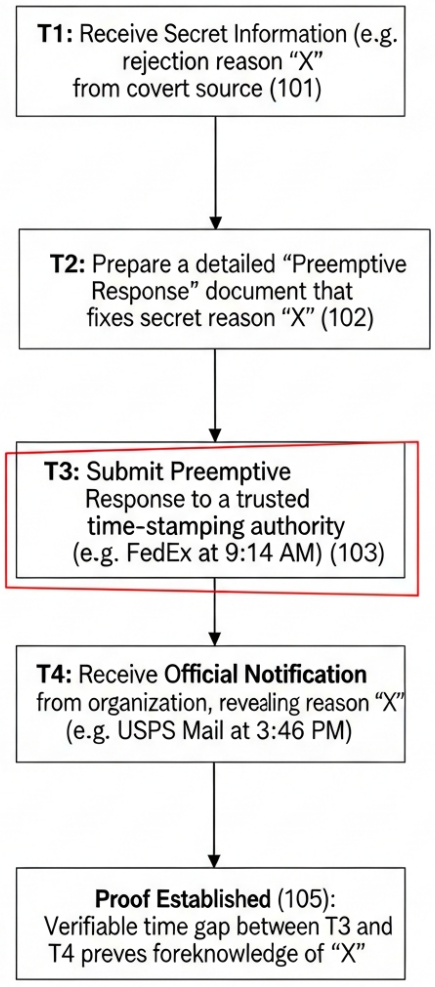


Figure 1: Timeline flowchart of the method.